accredited to Sun Tzu. Before the reforms, warfare was considered a gentleman's game where everyone played by the same rules. One did not wage war on the weak in fear of losing honor. Another example of early warfare suggested that an army should not charge if the other side was not prepared on the battlefield. Generals would allow enough time for the opponent to line up before attacking.

Shang encouraged the army to forgo these principles and win battles at any cost. His principles were used at Changping where more than 450,000 people were captured and then slaughtered. This allowed the Qin state to gain an advantage and rise above the others. It wasn't until King Ying Zheng that they employed these new military strategies. With Shang's reforms, a powerful army and weapons fashioned from iron, Ying Zheng was able to conquer the rest of the states one by one. In 221 BCE, he united all of the seven states under his banner and declared himself Shi Huangdi, or the First Emperor of China.